HYACINTH MACAW

Anodorhynchus hyacinthinus

Think About This

Who or what does your daily life depend on that you've never thanked?

What can I see or hear?

World's largest flying parrot — 3.3 ft long. Cobalt blue with yellow eye-ring. Beak strong enough to crack a coconut — bite force around 600+ PSI, the highest of any bird.

Where does it live, and why?

Pantanal wooded savanna. Nests almost exclusively in 60+ year old Manduvi trees. Two palm species feed it: Acrocomia and Attalea — its ecology is wired to those trees.

How does it send messages?

Loud rolling calls. Mates preen, feed, and 'kiss' each other. Pairs stay close and call back and forth in flight to keep contact.

What does it do when something changes?

Forages palm nuts in trees AND in cattle dung — cattle can't digest the nuts, so the macaw cracks the easier post-cattle shell. Cooperates with rodents that strip outer skin.

How does it learn?

Long juvenile period — chicks dependent for over a year. Learn complex feeding technique (some use leaf or wood tools to grip slippery nuts before cracking).

How does it have babies?

Pair-bonded for life. Breeds Aug to Nov in the Pantanal. 1 to 2 eggs in a tree hollow, ~28 day incubation. Female incubates, male feeds her. Slow recovery.

What are the limits?

Lifespan 30 to 50 years. Endangered — depends on old trees and on two palm species. Lose either, and the bird loses everything. Pet trade pressure remains.

What does this teach us?

Specialization is a contract with the environment. This bird trades flexibility for power — and depends on cattle, palms, rodents, and trees older than most people. Connection IS the diet.